Pashmina derives its name from 'pashm', the silken underfleece of the Changthangi goat, which lives in the high Himalayan regions of Nepal, Tibet, Ladakh and Kashmir. While there are several Pashmina varieties from these parts, the Kashmir bloodline produces the softest, warmest and lightest fibres, a micron fineness 1/5th of human hair, which is then handspun and handwoven by traditional artisans. Hence its other name, cashmere, a byword for the finest wool worldwide for centuries, favoured by the Mughal emperor Akbar and later the French empress, Josephine.



The goats start to moult naturally in the spring, so there is no cruel shearing. Harvesting is done by combing out the moult in the summer.





Much kinder than the method of obtaining the equally luxurious shahtoosh wool of the wild Tibetan antelope, which used to be methodically hunted and killed. Three to five antelopes were required to make one shahtoosh shawl. Gratefully, the trade in shahtoosh was banned globally by the early 1990s.

HiH Jan2024 links
See how Pashmina shawls are made and the many varieties. 3.39 mins
https://youtu.be/Fl4Z-_1jxTA?si=qAnqLSy3PZ72T4lY

Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

January 2024

The noblest wool







There are deeper reasons why Pashmina is special. Changthangi goats do not merely endure the mountainous conditions but seem to thrive on them. The -40 °C temperatures stimulate the growth of the downy fleece, make it softer and warmer. Nature at its most benign!

Between the shepherds, herders, spinners, dyers, weavers and embellishers, the Pashmina industry weaves not only exquisite textiles but ‘also a tapestry of economic opportunities’, supporting communities across Jammu, Kashmir and Ladakh.



Given this background, fake Pashmina – machine-made, blended with artificial fibres and brazen knock offs - naturally abounds.

HOW TO IDENTIFY REAL PASHMINA

Most bona fide retailers carry the GI seal of the Govt of India on genuine Pashmina

Real Pashmina is an open gauzy weave as it cannot tolerate high tension. It's usually woven with pure silk in a 70:30 ratio

If the piece you are buying has a high sheen, it's fake. Real Pashmina is matte

The real fabric is also more uneven and will pill with use – the formation of tiny fuzzy balls on the surface of the wool

Hold the pashmina in both hands and rub the two parts against one another. If there is any artificial fibre it will generate static electricity, cause a spark

Pure pashmina cannot hold glue of any kind for long. If there is a label stuck to it, the piece is probably a fake.



